

Scaling Community-Based Health Promotion: Insights From 20 Months of Cancer Screening and Prevention Outreach in BC

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Background

Community-based health promotion remains a key strategy for increasing uptake of cancer screening and prevention services in British Columbia. While 92% of residents express interest, awareness gaps exist for breast and cervix screening among women aged 18-34, and for colon and lung screening among adults aged 50-70¹.

Evidence shows in-person engagement can help bridge knowledge gaps through tailored information and trusted relationships². In 2024, BC Cancer's Prevention, Screening and Hereditary Cancer Program launched a community engagement pilot with the aim of bringing screening and prevention resources into people's everyday lives.

In 2025, the program expanded significantly, scaling to reach more communities, especially newcomers and other equity-deserving groups facing barriers to screening access.

Program Model

Booth Activations (High-Traffic Outreach)

- Large-scale local events such as marathons, expos and fairs
- Community hubs such as libraries and food banks
- Staffed by the health promotion team and trained post-secondary co-op students
- Introduced a new sun safety booth in 2025 focusing on skin cancer prevention (seasonal expansion)

Activities:

- Interactive trivia wheel
- Multilingual print and digital resources
- Postcards, salad kits, free sunscreen and other call-to-action giveaways

Community Workshops (Targeted Engagement)

- Co-delivered with community health centers, newcomer agencies, cultural/faith-based groups and other local organizations
- Supports specific populations eligible for breast, cervix, colon and lung screening

Features:

- Presentations with interpretation
- Trauma-informed facilitation with trusted local leaders
- On-site screening mammogram bookings
- On-site cervix self-screening kit distribution
- Wellness supports like food and childcare

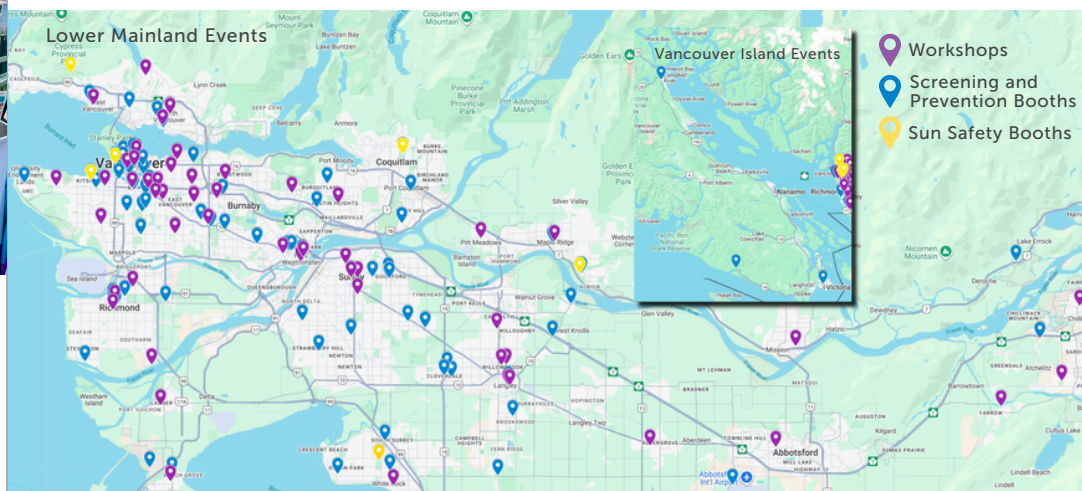
Participant and Partner Feedback

- Increased awareness of BC's screening and prevention programs
- Appreciation of BC Cancer's presence in community
- Reports of improved comfort, motivation and confidence accessing screening
- Interest from partner organizations for continued collaboration and co-design



Results

Community Engagement Map (January 2024 - September 2025)



Event Reach

- 124 unique booth activations
- 75 workshops delivered
- 27,000+ meaningful interactions with participants

Workshop Outcomes

- 100+ screening mammograms booked
- 210+ cervix self-screening kits distributed
- 30+ new partnerships formed in 2025

Conclusion

Over 20 months, our community engagement has evolved from a pilot initiative to a robust program. We hope to deepen its impact by continuing to leverage community strengths, enhancing uptake of screening and prevention across diverse populations.

Future work will focus on:

- Expanding co-designed models to meet growing partner demand.
- Integrating screening services into existing social support programs.
- Building a community of practice.

References

1. Mustel Group. (2023, August). Community Outreach Survey.
2. Bader, B., Coenen, M., Hummel, J., Schoenweger, P., Voss, S., & Jung-Stievers, C. (2023). Evaluation of community-based health promotion interventions in children and adolescents in high-income countries: a scoping review on strategies and methods used. BMC Public Health, 23(1), 845.

Our Goals

- ✓ Increase awareness of breast, cervix, colon and lung screening through culturally-relevant, event-based engagement.
- ✓ Offer cancer risk reduction strategies addressing sun safety, commercial tobacco, nutrition, physical activity, radon, air pollution, alcohol and HPV.
- ✓ Address contextual barriers by meeting communities where they are at, through tailored workshops, large-scale booth activations, and partnerships with local organizations.

